

Veterans Backbone – Boundaries & Professional Relationships Framework

Purpose

Healthy boundaries protect everyone.

They protect veterans, staff, volunteers, trustees, partners, and the organisation itself.

Boundaries are not barriers to connection. They are what make safe, respectful, and effective relationships possible.

This framework establishes the principles that guide relationships throughout Veterans Backbone.

Core Principle 1 – Human First

People should be treated with dignity, respect, compassion, and honesty.

Professional boundaries should never remove humanity.

Kindness and professionalism can exist together.

Core Principle 2 – Support Is Not Ownership

No member of staff, volunteer, trustee, or partner "owns" a veteran.

Support should encourage independence, not dependency.

Relationships should empower people to move forward, not become reliant on individuals.

Core Principle 3 – Clarity Protects Everyone

Clear expectations reduce confusion, conflict, and risk.

Roles, responsibilities, and limitations should be understood and communicated openly.

Core Principle 4 – Consistency Matters

Boundaries should be applied fairly and consistently.

Favouritism, special treatment, and informal exceptions create risk for everyone involved.

Core Principle 5 – Accountability Is Healthy

Boundaries create accountability.

Where concerns arise, they should be addressed openly, fairly, and proportionately.

Core Principle 6 – Relationships Must Remain Safe

Professional relationships must never place individuals at risk of harm, exploitation, manipulation, coercion, or dependency.

Safety always comes first.

Core Principle 7 – Boundaries Support Recovery

Boundaries are not about control.

They provide predictability, trust, safety, and stability.

For many veterans, healthy boundaries are an essential part of recovery and rebuilding confidence.

Final Statement

Boundaries are not about keeping people at arm's length.

They exist so that relationships remain safe, respectful, effective, and sustainable for everyone involved.